

AN INTRODUCTION

THIS BOOK IS THE RECORD OF A BUSINESS TRIP. I TOOK IT IN THE name of all regular people who feel they know next to nothing about the financial world, and yet have some money and wonder how to invest it. How often have you muttered to yourself: *If only I had enough spare time to study the stock market, I could make a fortune.* How often have you heard your friends say: "It's silly to go to work for a living when there's so much profit on Wall Street." With half a chance, a common-sense person could make the money do work, just as the Wall Street professionals claim to do.

In the late summer of 1985, during an extraordinary bull market, I decided to drop everything and devote an entire year to learning how to invest, especially in stocks. I resolved to begin at the beginning, finding out as much as I could about the business and how it really operates, meanwhile putting my own funds into whatever would make the biggest profit. After adopting the winning strategy, increasing my net worth, and achieving financial independence, I'd return to tell you how I did it.

At this point, an actual accounting of gains and losses would ruin the suspense, but let me assure you that writing this book has nothing to do with my needing the money. I know there's widespread suspicion that people write investment books because they need the royalties to make up for their own unprofitable investments, or else they'd be sunning themselves on some Caribbean island instead of staring at a word processor, but in my case, the suspicion is unfounded. I've recently discovered that sitting in front of a word processor is a great delight and preferable to any Caribbean vacation. Plus I have a philanthropic interest in helping